

KINGDOM LIFE MINISTRY

The Feast of Tabernacles

Sukkot, the booth you can take down, and the Elohim who came to camp with His people

Scripture from the World English Bible, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai.

THE HEART OF IT. Seven days in something you can take down, so your children know who kept Israel alive in the wilderness, and so you remember that the One who tented among us is coming back to camp with His people for good.

A free printable teaching handout from Kingdom Life Ministry.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

What This Is and What It Is Not

This walks through what Scripture says about the Feast of Tabernacles, what the booth was for, who has already fulfilled part of it, and what is still out ahead. Read the passages as you go. If anything here does not match the text, go with the text.

- This is one of YHWH's appointed times, given in Leviticus 23 with the Sabbath and the rest of them. He calls them His feasts, not Israel's and not the Jews'.
- Everything about the booth in here comes from Scripture. Where Scripture gives no measurement and no rule, none is invented here.
- This is the one feast Scripture commands you to be glad at. If your observance ends up solemn and heavy, something went wrong.
- Like every appointed day, it runs evening to evening.

You will not get this one out of a book. Build the thing, sleep in it, and let your kids wake up in it. The instruction was never to study booths. It was to live in one for a week.

PART I

The Feast YHWH Named

Five days after the Day of Atonement, the mood changes completely. Fasting is over. This one comes with a command to rejoice.

1. The Fifteenth Day of the Seventh Month

The timing is deliberate. Trumpets, then ten days, then the Day of Atonement, then five more days and the camp goes up. You do not get to the celebration without walking through the repentance first. That order is the whole shape of the seventh month.

YHWH spoke to Moses, saying, *Speak to the children of Israel, and say, On the fifteenth day of this seventh month is the feast of booths for seven days to YHWH.*

Leviticus 23:33-34

2. Seven Days, and Be Glad

Most of what YHWH tells Israel to do is an instruction about conduct. Here He tells them how to feel, and then repeats it. Rejoice. Be altogether joyful. It lands right after the harvest is in, which is when you can finally see what the year actually gave you.

You shall keep the feast of booths seven days, after you have gathered in from your threshing floor and from your wine press. You shall rejoice in your feast. Because YHWH your Elohim will bless you in all your increase and in all the work of your hands, and you shall be altogether joyful.

Deuteronomy 16:13-15

3. He Said Why

YHWH rarely explains Himself, so when He does, stop and read it twice. The booths are not decoration and they are not a harvest tradition He borrowed. They are a memory device, built for the generations who were not there.

You shall dwell in booths seven days. All who are native-born in Israel shall dwell in booths, that your generations may know that I made the children of Israel to dwell in booths when I brought them out of the land of Egypt. I am YHWH your Elohim.

Leviticus 23:42-43

PART II

The Booth Itself

This is where people get nervous, usually because somebody handed them a page of rules that are not in the text. Here is what the text says.

4. Branches and Boughs

Fruit from good trees, palm branches, leafy branches, and willows from the creek. That is the material list, and it is the kind of list you can fill by walking outside. Nothing about it requires a supplier or a kit.

You shall take on the first day the fruit of majestic trees, branches of palm trees, and boughs of thick trees, and willows of the brook; and you shall rejoice before YHWH your Elohim seven days.

Leviticus 23:40

5. Nehemiah's Generation Went and Got Branches

They found it written, and they went out and did it, and the text says nobody had kept it that way since Joshua. Centuries of missing it, and the fix was not a committee. They read it and went to the hills for branches. Then look at the last line of that passage.

Go out to the mountain, and get olive branches, branches of wild olive, myrtle branches, palm branches, and branches of thick trees, to make temporary shelters, as it is written. All the assembly of those who had come back out of the captivity made temporary shelters and lived in the temporary shelters; for since the days of Jeshua the son of Nun to that day the children of Israel had not done so. There was very great gladness.

Nehemiah 8:15-17

6. What Scripture Does Not Say

No dimensions. No wall count. No rules about how much sky has to show through the roof. Those things came later and they came from men. What Scripture gives you is three things: make it from branches, make it temporary, and live in it for seven days. Build it with your kids and let it be a little crooked.

Whatever thing I command you, that you shall observe to do. You shall not add to it, nor take away from it.

Deuteronomy 12:32

PART III

Why It Has to Be Temporary

A permanent building would defeat the entire point. The flimsiness is the message.

You cannot learn dependence in a house that does not move. That is why He picked a booth and not a sanctuary.

7. So the Next Generation Knows

A story told at a table is one thing. A week spent sleeping under branches while the weather does whatever it wants is another. Your children will not remember the teaching. They will remember the year the wind came up and the roof rattled and dad said this is exactly the point.

You shall remember all the way which YHWH your Elohim has led you these forty years in the wilderness, that he might humble you, testing you, to know what was in your heart. He humbled you, and allowed you to be hungry, and fed you with manna, which you didn't know.

Deuteronomy 8:2-3

8. Abraham Lived in Tents Too

The man who was given the land never built a house on it. He stayed in tents his whole life inside the promise, because he had his eye on something with foundations that he was not going to see yet. A booth for a week is a small version of that same posture.

By faith he lived as an alien in the land of promise, as in a land not his own, dwelling in tents with Isaac and Jacob, the heirs with him of the same promise. For he was looking for the city which has foundations, whose builder and maker is Elohim.

Hebrews 11:9-10

9. This Body Is a Tent

Paul uses the same picture for the body you are reading this in. Temporary, held together with not much, and not the thing you were promised. Seven days in a shelter made of branches makes that easier to feel than any amount of explaining does.

For we know that if the earthly house of our tent is dissolved, we have a building from Elohim, a house not made with hands, eternal, in the heavens.

2 Corinthians 5:1

PART IV

The One Who Came to Camp With Us

Every feast points at Yahshua. This one does it with a word most translations smooth over.

10. The Word Pitched a Tent Among Us

The Greek behind lived among us is built on the word for tent. He tabernacled with us. Not visited, not appeared, not sent word. He pitched His tent in the camp and stayed. If you have ever wondered whether Tabernacles has anything to do with Him, that is John telling you in the first chapter.

The Word became flesh, and lived among us. We saw his glory, such glory as of the one and only Son of the Father, full of grace and truth.

John 1:14

11. The Last and Greatest Day of the Feast

He picked the last day of this feast, the biggest day of the week, and stood up and shouted in the middle of it. Everything about where and when He said it was on purpose.

Now on the last and greatest day of the feast, Yahshua stood and cried out, If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink! He who believes in me, as the Scripture has said, from within him will flow rivers of living water.

John 7:37-38

12. His Pavilion

The shelter runs both directions. You build one for a week, and He is the one you are actually hidden inside of. That is worth sitting with on the first night, once the branches are up and everybody else has gone quiet.

For in the day of trouble he will keep me secretly in his pavilion. In the covert of his tabernacle he will hide me.

Psalms 27:5

PART V

What Is Still Ahead

Passover, Unleavened Bread, Firstfruits, and Pentecost have all been fulfilled. Tabernacles has not, not fully, and Scripture is not vague about where it goes.

Every nation left standing keeps this feast. That is not a Christian reading pushed onto the text. That is Zechariah.

13. Every Nation Will Keep It

Whatever anybody tells you about the feasts being done away with, this is a future tense verse about nations that are not Israel going up to keep this particular feast. It is hard to square that with the idea that it expired.

It will happen that everyone who is left of all the nations that came against Jerusalem will go up from year to year to worship the King, YHWH of Armies, and to keep the feast of booths.

Zechariah 14:16

14. Palm Branches in the Multitude

John sees a crowd nobody can count, from every nation, holding the same branches Leviticus named. He does not stop to explain why, because anyone who had ever kept the feast would recognize what they were holding.

Behold, a great multitude which no man could count, out of every nation and of all tribes, peoples, and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, dressed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands.

Revelation 7:9

15. He Will Tabernacle With Men

Here is the feast in its finished form. Not a week. Not branches. Him, dwelling with His people, and it does not come down at the end of seven days.

Behold, Elohim's dwelling is with people, and he will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and Elohim himself will be with them as their Elohim.

Revelation 21:3

16. The Eighth Day

Seven days, then a separate day tacked on the end and given its own name. A solemn assembly, no regular work, standing apart from the week it follows. Eight is the number of new beginnings all through Scripture, and this is the day we hold the wedding supper of the Lamb belongs on. Seven days camped with Him, and then a feast that starts something that does not end.

Seven days you shall offer an offering made by fire to YHWH. On the eighth day shall be a holy convocation to you. You shall offer an offering made by fire to YHWH. It is a solemn assembly; you shall do no regular work.

Leviticus 23:36

Let's rejoice and be exceedingly glad, and let's give the glory to him. For the wedding of the Lamb has come, and his wife has made herself ready. Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb.

Revelation 19:7, 9

PART VI

How We Keep It

This is what our house does. It is not a rule for yours. Take what is useful and leave the rest.

17. We Go

We travel to a campground and keep it with a big group. We live in temporary dwellings for the week and we build a sukkah from what Scripture describes, branches and boughs, nothing engineered. Going somewhere matters more than we expected it to. You leave the house, the routine, the job, and the comfortable bed, and by about day three something in you has actually let go of them.

Don't be grieved, for the joy of YHWH is your strength.

Nehemiah 8:10

18. Keep It With Other People

Seven days with one family is a camping trip. Seven days with a group is the feast. The meals are shared, the kids run in a pack until dark, and the conversations that happen around a fire on night four do not happen anywhere else on the calendar. If you have nobody to keep it with yet, start asking now, because that is the part that takes the longest to build.

You shall rejoice in your feast, you, and your son, and your daughter, and your male servant, and your female servant, and the Levite, and the foreigner, and the fatherless, and the widow who are within your gates.

Deuteronomy 16:14

19. If You Have Never Done This Before

Do not wait until you can do it perfectly. A tarp and some branches in the back yard counts. One night counts. Eat a meal in it, sleep in it if you can, read Leviticus 23 out loud in it with your family, and tell your kids why it is made of sticks. Next year you will do more. The generation that restarted this under Nehemiah had not kept it in centuries, and the text does not record one word of criticism about how they did it. It records very great gladness.

Beloved, I beg you as foreigners and pilgrims to abstain from fleshly lusts which war against the soul.

1 Peter 2:11

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Every prayer in this guide is anchored to Scripture. If you disagree with something written here, go to the text and let the text settle it.

FOR YOUR OWN WORDS

Notes

Write down what you want to remember from this week, who kept it with you, and what you want to do differently next year. Read it again before you build.

Israel camped in booths because they had nowhere else to be. We build them on purpose, for a week, so we do not forget that everything solid we think we are standing on is borrowed. He tented with us once. He is coming back to do it permanently.

Kingdom Life Ministry

Restoring YHWH's design for marriage, family, forgiveness, and deliverance.

Walk in truth, walk in light. Shalom.